

ADHD CHILD PARENTING STRATEGY TOOLKIT

Visual Schedules, Reward Systems & Coping Tools

for Parents of Neurodivergent Kids (Ages 4-12)

By Daniel Tesfamariam

PARENTING AN ADHD CHILD: WHAT WORKS

Traditional parenting strategies often FAIL with ADHD kids because their brains process rewards, time, and motivation differently.

WHAT WORKS:

- VISUAL systems (they can't hold info in working memory)
- IMMEDIATE rewards (delayed gratification is harder)
- SHORTER tasks (break everything into 5-10 min chunks)
- EXTERNAL structure (they can't create internal structure yet)
- MOVEMENT breaks (sitting still depletes their energy)
- CONNECTION before correction (shame makes ADHD worse)

VISUAL MORNING ROUTINE CHART

(Laminate and hang in bedroom/bathroom!)

MORNING ROUTINE (Do in this order!):

- [1] ☐ Wake up - sit up in bed!
- [2] ☐ Use the bathroom
- [3] ☐ Brush teeth (timer: 2 min)
- [4] ☐ Get dressed (clothes laid out last night!)
- [5] ☐ Eat breakfast
- [6] ☐ Pack backpack (check list!)
- [7] ☐ Shoes on, ready to go!
- [8] ☐ OUT THE DOOR by ____:____ AM

PARENT TIP: Let child check off steps themselves. Each checkmark = dopamine!

BONUS: If all done by ____:____, earn _____!

AFTER-SCHOOL ROUTINE CHART

- [1] ☐ Snack time (15 min - refuel!)
- [2] ☐ Movement break (10 min - run, jump, dance!)
- [3] ☐ Homework time (set timer: ____ minutes)
- [4] ☐ Break (5 min)
- [5] ☐ More homework if needed (timer again)
- [6] ☐ Free time / play!
- [7] ☐ Dinner
- [8] ☐ Evening routine (below)

KEY: Movement BEFORE homework. A tired ADHD brain cannot focus!

BEDTIME ROUTINE CHART

- [1] ☐ Screens OFF (30 min before bed!)
- [2] ☐ Bath/shower
- [3] ☐ Pajamas on
- [4] ☐ Brush teeth
- [5] ☐ Pick tomorrow's clothes
- [6] ☐ Read together (or audiobook)
- [7] ☐ Calm-down activity (coloring, puzzle, breathing)
- [8] ☐ Lights out by __: __
- [9] ☐ Goodnight ritual: _____

TIP: Same order EVERY night. Predictability = security for ADHD brains.

ADHD-FRIENDLY REWARD SYSTEM

ADHD brains need EXTERNAL motivation. This isn't bribery - it's brain science!

TOKEN BOARD (earn tokens, trade for rewards):

EARN TOKENS FOR:

- * Routine completed (morning/afternoon/bedtime) = 1 token
- * Homework done without major battle = 2 tokens
- * Kind to siblings = 1 token
- * Tried something hard = 1 token
- * Remembered something without reminding = 2 tokens!

SPEND TOKENS ON:

- 5 tokens = Extra screen time (30 min)
- 10 tokens = Choose dinner / Pick a movie
- 15 tokens = Special outing with parent
- 20 tokens = New book/toy (under \$10)
- 30 tokens = BIG reward: _____

TOKENS EARNED: [] [] [] [] [] [] [] [] [] []
[] [] [] [] [] [] [] [] [] []

HOMEWORK STATION SETUP GUIDE

Create a distraction-free zone that works WITH ADHD:

LOCATION: ☐ Desk in room ☐ Kitchen table ☐ Quiet corner
(Wherever YOU can supervise without hovering)

STATION MUST HAVES:

- ☐ Timer (visual timer best - they can SEE time passing)
- ☐ Fidget tool (quiet one: putty, stress ball, tangle)
- ☐ Noise-canceling headphones OR white noise
- ☐ All supplies within reach (pencils, eraser, sharpener)
- ☐ Water bottle (hydration helps focus!)
- ☐ Clear desk surface (nothing extra - only current task)
- ☐ Checklist of assignments (visible, checkable)

HOMEWORK STRATEGY: 10 min work -> 3 min break -> 10 min work -> 3 min break
(Adjust times to your child: some do better with 15/5, some need 7/3)

SENSORY BREAK MENU

When your child is dysregulated, overwhelmed, or can't focus - offer a SENSORY BREAK:

HIGH ENERGY (burn it off):

- ☐ Jump on trampoline
- ☐ Run laps around house
- ☐ Dance to one song
- ☐ 10 jumping jacks
- ☐ Push-ups against wall

CALMING (settle down):

- ☐ Deep pressure (tight hug, weighted blanket)
- ☐ Swing or rock
- ☐ Play with water/sand
- ☐ Listen to calm music
- ☐ Blow bubbles (controlled breathing)

FOCUSING (get ready to work):

- ☐ Chew gum or crunchy snack
- ☐ Fidget tool
- ☐ Cold water on wrists
- ☐ Stretching
- ☐ 5 deep breaths

TEACHER COMMUNICATION TEMPLATE

Send at start of school year + as needed:

Dear [Teacher],

My child [name] has ADHD. Here's what helps them succeed:

WORKS WELL: _____

STRUGGLES WITH: _____

HELPFUL STRATEGIES: _____

TRIGGERS TO WATCH FOR: _____

BEST WAY TO CONTACT ME: _____

My child is creative, energetic, and caring. Thank you for supporting them! I'm happy to collaborate anytime.

- [Your name]

By Daniel Tesfamariam | ADHD is a superpower that needs the right support system.